

FOREVER and Ever and EVER

Pawan Kumar Chamling authors a rare success story as he takes charge for a record fourth term and says he will go for a fifth

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

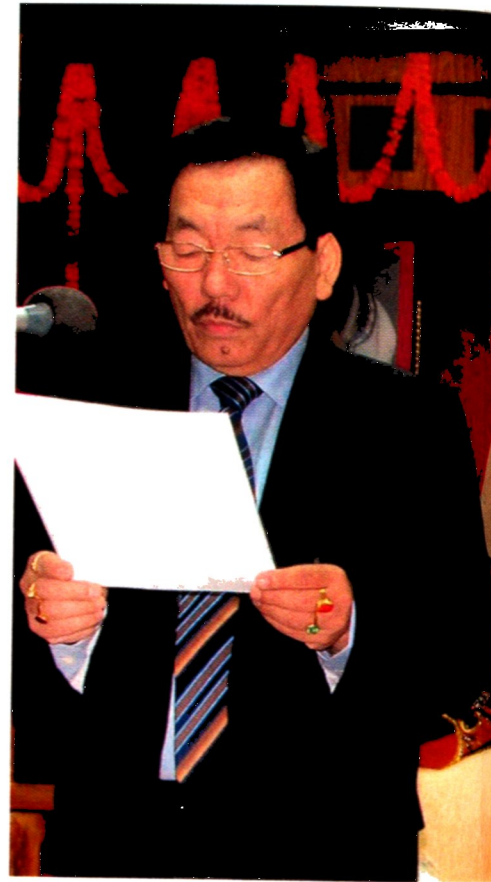
India has seen many electoral land-slides but Sikkim continues to provide poll miracles. In the Sikkimese political lexicon, the word anti-incumbency just does not exist. For that matter, even the Opposition doesn't exist as was evident in the elections to the state Assembly where Chief Minister Pawan Kumar Chamling's Sikkim Democratic Front (SDF) won all 32 seats, and he was sworn in as the state's chief minister for the fourth consecutive term last week.

Shortly after taking oath, the 53-year-old was quick to announce that he wants to rule "for at least another 15 years" so that he can take the state's cause forward and complete all the development projects that his SDF Government promised the people, his main election plank for the last three terms. A school dropout, Chamling is clearly not lacking in vision and means business. For most people in the state, there could not have been a better ray of hope and they have reposed faith in Chamling again, giving him victory in all the 32 Assembly seats of the state as well as the lone Lok Sabha constituency.

Fifty-eight-year-old P.D. Rai, first-time MP from Sikkim and a suave corporate professional, says Chamling's charm lies in his humility and his wide connect with people at the grassroots level. "His political acumen is by far the best among all the politicians that I have seen. He is second to none," Rai says, adding that Chamling realises that the best way to gain the confidence of the people is to ensure development at all levels with a modern outlook, which is why he enlisted the services of corporates and qualified managers in his team. "He has a brand new young and dynamic team and the thrust is to deliver or perish," says Rai.

Significantly, Chamling's new 12-member Cabinet has eight first-time ministers who have been MLAs earlier and three are first-timers, including two women. "Forty-five per cent of his votebank consists of the youth between 18 and 30 years of age. Add to this his emphasis on programmes for women and you have a sure winner," says C.B. Karki, SDF legislator.

Incidentally, Chamling dropped 22 sitting MLAs this time, set them up as chairmen of local party committees and asked them to groom the youth as



PAWAN CHAMLING (LEFT) BEING SWORN IN AS THE CHIEF MINISTER BY GOVERNOR BALMIKI PRASAD SINGH

future leaders. "You have done enough from the Assembly and I can see the rust. Please go out and work with the people. Teach them how to get involved in politics and groom the youth. That should be your job now," he told a full-house party meeting six months back. Waiting with a red carpet to greet what it thought would be a procession of disgruntled MLAs, the BJP got the rudest shock of all when none of the SDF legislators left Chamling. The BJP was left high and dry.

A lot is keeping the man busy these days as he attends numerous meetings and does not even carry a mobile. His popularity is indeed contagious and spontaneous as opposition leader and former chief minister Nar Bahadur Bhandari has come to realise. Bhandari, who merged his Sikkim Sangram Parishad with the Congress after being trounced by